

DARJEELING | Silent Hills



PTI

When Madan Tamang, the 62-year-old president of the All India Gorkha League, was brutally hacked down in Darjeeling last week, many said they would rather stay with West Bengal than be deprived of their right to free expression in a fear-ruled Gorkhaland.

Such sentiments must have sounded sweet to the West Bengal Government and it acted quickly to push the wedge between the people and the Gorkha Janmukti Morcha (GJM), the hill party spearheading the demand for a separate state. Seeing the people openly defy the GJM by closing down the region for four days, Ashok Bhattacharya, minister for urban development and municipal affairs, said: "The GJM has lost the mandate of the people. We cannot hold talks with them." The GJM may be on the back foot, but there is still no viable political formation that can take the tripartite talks forward, despite the recent formation of the Democratic Front comprising other parties.

by Joel Rai



Defence Minister A.K. Antony and his deputy Pallam Raju were to be the chief guests at the unveiling of India's new light attack helicopter in Bangalore but opted out because of the Mangalore crash. The helicopter still made its debut.

LUCKNOW | Minority Junction

All roads seemed to lead to Azamgarh. Amar Singh hotfooted into the district just after Congress strategist Digvijay Singh and Imam Ahmed Bukhari, aiming to smoothen ruffled local feathers. Accompanied by friend Jaya Prada and firebrand leader Obaidullah Azmi, Amar drew an impressive crowd in Mubarakpur as he addressed the weavers of the famous Banarasi silk sari, now starving for jobs. "I am your friend and brother and would continue to raise *Ya Ali* in Parliament till your problems are addressed," he promised, pate covered by a white fur cap. Backed by Congress-led UPA, Amar is leaving no stone unturned in his mission to demolish his friend-turned-foe Samajwadi Party chief Mulayam

AMAR SINGH IN AZAMGARH



SUDHIR SINGH

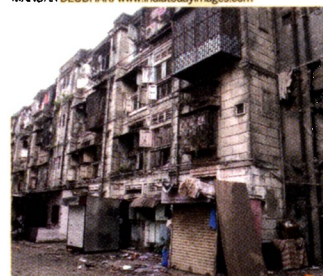
Singh's hold in favourite constituency community—the Muslims. If the crowds are a barometer then Mulayam should be worried. Unlike Digvijay and Bukhari, whose visits created controversies, Amar was a hit.

by Subhash Mishra

MUMBAI | Close Quarters

Looks like the housing crunch in Mumbai has not spared the city police either. Nearly 1,500 constables have chosen to live in rented houses instead of the police quarters. That is because those that do live in the old quarters of Naigaon and Mahim face unhygienic conditions where families must share bathrooms. Many official quarters for the police are in deplorable conditions, too small for families and are therefore lying vacant. The Government is building new quarters at six

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SHABBY ACCOMMODATION

new places which will be bigger, says a source. Just 44 per cent of the police staff lives in government houses and ironically they end up paying most of their salary on the rent. Among the old police quarters, only the one in Bandra is seen as liveable. Hardly the benefit to give to a force that tackles both thieves and terrorists.

by Mitali Patel